



Persian ceramic and gold leaf ewer
1200–1399 • IRAN

It was prohibited to make drinking vessels from gold and silver, as these were considered indulgent, so Islamic craftsmen became expert in alternatives such as ceramic, which was then richly decorated.



Bronze vase
18TH CENTURY • CHINA

Although this bronze vase from China displays a text from the Qu'ran in Arabic, it nonetheless shows clear Chinese influence.

Star-shaped tile
1267 • IRAN

Though distinctively Islamic in its use of luster (a ceramic technology mimicking gilding) and arabesques (stylized foliage), this tile shows Mongol influence with the inclusion of doglike animals.



THE ISLAMIC WORLD

TECHNOLOGICAL INNOVATION AND RELIGIOUS INSPIRATION COMBINE TO CREATE A UNIQUE HERITAGE OF ARTS AND CRAFTS

Islamic arts and crafts were shaped by religious restrictions, cultural heritage acquired through conquest, and the elaboration of unique features, notably the use of ornamentation and color, and inclusion of Arabic script.

Through its rapid conquest of a huge empire, the Islamic caliphate was exposed to a diverse mix of cultural styles and heritages; Islamic art reflects these while maintaining a high degree of homogeneity due to religious uniformity. Restrictions imposed by Islam, such as prohibitions on representative art and on the use of gold and silver, generated creative responses, especially stylized abstract designs, elaborate ornamentation, strong use of color, and the use of Arabic script and Qu'ranic quotations.



inlaid with
ornate
foliage

inscription
reads "Allah,
Muhammad,
Fatima, and
'Ali, Hasan,
and Husayn"

Jade necklace
1875–1925 • ORIGIN UNKNOWN

This jade necklace is made from five pieces, all different in shape and engraved with verses from the Qu'ran. Such artifacts could serve as amulets with quasi-magical powers.

Surgical scissors and scalpel
10TH CENTURY • ORIGIN UNKNOWN
Islamic physicians made huge advances in medicine and surgery, including devising a range of surgical instruments such as the *mibda* (scalpel) and *miqass* (scissors).

Khanjar
19TH CENTURY • INDIA

Although from India, this curved, double-edged dagger is actually a traditional Omani blade. It is decorated with ornate foliate, a typical Islamic motif.

Pendant
18TH CENTURY • INDIA

From the Indian Mughal Empire, this gold pendant shows how Muslim rulers sometimes disregarded prohibitions on representative art and the use of precious metals.

Coins
720–910 • SYRIA/EGYPT
Coins from the Umayyad and Abbasid caliphates, minted in Damascus and Cairo, bear Arabic text in place of pictures of heads of state.

Ornate gilded Shi'ite alam
17TH CENTURY • IRAN
This alam, or standard, made of brass and gold, symbolically recalls the Shi'ite standard planted at the Battle of Kerbala in 680.

